

Assessment and legacy

Assessing the historical personality of Alexander is difficult for a number of reasons. The authors of the ancient written sources that have survived all wrote after his death.

Some of them, like Arrian, made use of histories and documents written at the time of Alexander's campaigns and tell us who or what they were. Most don't tell us where they got their evidence. Some are coloured by the fact that Alexander's

exploits soon became 'romanticised' or exaggerated after his death.

Most of the available archaeological evidence has also been affected by either political propaganda by Alexander or someone else's admiration of Alexander's 'greatness'. Many of the coins showing Alexander were actually minted by the Macedonian generals who claimed parts of his empire for themselves after he died. They wanted to show a link to him in

order to legitimise their political position. You must be critical of the ancient sources that are available to you when you study Alexander. When assessing Alexander and his achievements the following questions need to be examined:

- Was he a great general or military leader?
- Was he a good administrator or statesman?
- Were his achievements long-lasting?

A great general?

To assess Alexander's military ability, historians need to judge his ability to plan his actions (logistics), to achieve his long-term goals (strategy), to win a battle (tactics), and to lead and inspire his troops.

Logistical planning

The distances needed to be covered by his army across extremely harsh terrain, severe climatic extremes, and often, vast distances between cultivated inhabited regions were major obstacles. Alexander took his army of some 40 000 to 60 000 men across this land and, apart from one setback in Gedrosia, managed to supply and feed them. Using US Army statistics as a measure, Alexander's army needed some 338 600 litres of water alone each day. Grain and food for the horses was similarly needed in great quantities. According to DW Engels, Alexander managed this because of 'his superior abilities in gathering intelligence, planning, preparation and organisation'. He was aided by experienced officers, like Parmenio, to whom the actual tasks of supply were delegated. Arrian tells us that on many occasions Alexander would split up his forces for marches

through the country. This helped to increase the army's chances of providing its men and animals with food and water while travelling.

Strategic skill

The huge size of the Persian Empire and its military and naval resources meant that Alexander had to plan his actions carefully. His initial concern was to protect his home base, Greece and Macedonia, against Persian counterattack. The defeat of the Persian forces in Asia Minor was a priority. He managed this at Granicus and by securing the Ionian coastline. Next he had to eliminate any chance of the Persian navy cutting off his supplies and reinforcements from Macedon. He did this by capturing the Persian naval bases in Ionia and Phoenicia—Miletus, Halicarnassus, Tyre, Egypt and Cyrene—before he advanced into the interior of the Persian Empire.